

Pre-Authorisation Requirement Matrix

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS

OPERATIONS POLICY: PRE-AUTHORIZATION REQUIREMENTS FOR OUTPATIENT SERVICES

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1.0 PURPOSE

1.1 This policy defines the pre-authorization requirements for specific outpatient medical procedures and services provided under Meridian Health Partners' administered plans: MERIDIAN-GOLD, MERIDIAN-SILVER, MERIDIAN-BRONZE, and CIVIC-BASE.

1.2 The objective is to ensure appropriate utilization of services, adherence to clinical guidelines, and clarity for providers and members regarding necessary administrative processes prior to service delivery.

2.0 SCOPE

2.1 This policy applies to all Meridian Health Partners' employed and affiliated providers, billing staff, and administrative personnel involved in the ordering, scheduling, and processing of outpatient medical services for members enrolled in the aforementioned health plans.

2.2 This policy covers elective and non-emergent outpatient services. Emergency services requiring immediate life-saving intervention do not require prior authorization, but notification within 48 business hours post-stabilization is required.

3.0 GENERAL PRE-AUTHORIZATION GUIDELINES

3.1 All pre-authorization requests must be submitted through the Meridian Provider Portal or via fax to (555) 123-4567.

3.2 A complete pre-authorization request includes the member's identification information, referring provider details, CPT code(s) for the requested service, the facility where the service will be rendered, and all pertinent clinical documentation as specified in Section 4.0.

3.3 Standard Approval Window: Unless otherwise specified, Meridian Health Partners' Utilization Review Department will process complete pre-authorization requests within five (5) business days of receipt.

3.4 Urgent Approval Window: For urgent requests where delaying care for five business days would significantly jeopardize the member's life or health, providers must clearly mark the request as "URGENT." These requests will be processed within two (2) business days.

3.5 Retrospective Authorization: Services rendered without prior authorization, where pre-authorization was required, are subject to denial. Retrospective authorization may be considered only in documented emergency situations or unforeseen clinical deterioration that prevented prospective submission, with review completed within ten (10) business days of submission.

3.6 Validity of Authorization: An approved pre-authorization is valid for ninety (90) calendar days from the date of approval, unless otherwise specified in the approval letter. If the service is not rendered within this period, a new pre-authorization request must be submitted.

4.0 PROCEDURE-SPECIFIC PRE-AUTHORIZATION REQUIREMENTS

The following table outlines specific pre-authorization requirements by procedure and health plan:

4.1 Magnetic Resonance Imaging (MRI) of the Brain (with or without contrast)

4.1.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required.

4.1.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.1.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.1.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.1.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.1.6 Clinical Documentation: Referring provider's clinical notes detailing specific neurological symptoms (e.g., persistent headaches, focal neurological deficits), duration of symptoms, failed conservative management (if applicable), and any prior relevant imaging reports.

4.1.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.2 Computed Tomography (CT) Scan of the Abdomen and Pelvis (with or without contrast)

4.2.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required.

4.2.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.2.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.2.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.2.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.2.6 Clinical Documentation: Referring provider's clinical notes detailing abdominal pain characteristics, fever, weight loss, unexplained gastrointestinal symptoms, abnormal lab values (e.g., LFTs, amylase/lipase), and prior imaging results.

4.2.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.3 Screening Colonoscopy (average risk, no symptoms)

4.3.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required for members aged 45-75.

4.3.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for members aged 45-75.

4.3.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all ages.

4.3.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all ages.

4.3.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.3.6 Clinical Documentation: Member's age, date of last colonoscopy (if applicable), and family history of colorectal cancer or polyps.

4.3.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.4 Upper Endoscopy (Esophagogastroduodenoscopy - EGD)

4.4.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required.

4.4.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.4.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.4.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.4.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.4.6 Clinical Documentation: Referring provider's notes detailing persistent dyspepsia, dysphagia, GERD unresponsive to PPI therapy for 8 weeks, unexplained weight loss, iron deficiency anemia, or alarm symptoms (e.g., GI bleeding).

4.4.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.5 Total Knee Arthroplasty (Replacement)

4.5.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.5.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.5.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.5.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.5.5 Approval Window: 10 business days (Complex Case).

4.5.6 Clinical Documentation: Orthopedic surgeon's consultation notes, X-ray/MRI reports demonstrating severe osteoarthritis, documentation of failed conservative management (e.g., 6 months of physical therapy, NSAIDs, corticosteroid injections), and functional limitation assessment (e.g., WOMAC score).

4.5.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.6 Lumbar Fusion Surgery

4.6.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.6.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.6.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.6.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.6.5 Approval Window: 10 business days (Complex Case).

4.6.6 Clinical Documentation: Neurosurgeon/Orthopedic Spine Surgeon consultation notes, MRI/CT imaging demonstrating spinal instability, severe disc degeneration, or nerve root compression, documentation of failed extensive conservative management (e.g., 12 months of physical therapy, chiropractic care, epidural steroid injections, pain management), and functional limitation assessment.

4.6.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.7 Physical Therapy (Initial Course of Treatment, up to 12 visits)

4.7.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required for the first 12 visits per injury/condition per calendar year. Subsequent visits require pre-authorization.

4.7.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all visits.

4.7.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all visits.

4.7.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all visits.

4.7.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.7.6 Clinical Documentation: Referring provider's order, initial physical therapy evaluation including objective findings, functional deficits, plan of care with specific goals, and anticipated duration of treatment.

4.7.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Ms. Clara Jenkins, Director of Ancillary Services. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.8 Bariatric Surgery (e.g., Gastric Bypass, Sleeve Gastrectomy)

4.8.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.8.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.8.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.8.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.8.5 Approval Window: 10 business days (Complex Case).

4.8.6 Clinical Documentation: Documentation of BMI ≥ 40 kg/m² or BMI ≥ 35 kg/m² with at least one obesity-related comorbidity (e.g., diabetes, severe sleep apnea, uncontrolled hypertension), completion of a supervised medical weight loss program (minimum 6 months) within the last 2 years, psychological evaluation, nutritional counseling assessment, and specialist surgeon's evaluation.

4.8.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.9 Sleep Study (Polysomnography)

4.9.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required for home sleep studies. Facility-based studies require pre-authorization.

4.9.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all sleep studies.

4.9.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all sleep studies.

4.9.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all sleep studies.

4.9.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.9.6 Clinical Documentation: Referring provider's notes detailing symptoms suggestive of sleep apnea (e.g., loud snoring, witnessed apneas, daytime somnolence, fatigue), Epworth Sleepiness Scale score, and physical exam findings (e.g., BMI, neck circumference).

4.9.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.10 Chemotherapy (Initial Cycle of a New Regimen)

4.10.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.10.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.10.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.10.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.10.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard). Urgent requests for rapidly progressing malignancies will be processed within 2 business days.

4.10.6 Clinical Documentation: Oncologist's consultation notes, definitive pathology report confirming malignancy, stage of cancer, proposed chemotherapy regimen (drug names, dosages, frequency), and relevant lab results.

4.10.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Evelyn Reed, Oncology Lead. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.11 PET Scan (Positron Emission Tomography)

4.11.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.11.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.11.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.11.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.11.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.11.6 Clinical Documentation: Referring specialist's notes, prior imaging reports (CT, MRI) indicating equivocal findings or suspected metastasis, definitive pathology report (if applicable), and clear clinical question for which the PET scan is being requested (e.g., staging, restaging, evaluation of treatment response, characterization of indeterminate lesion).

4.11.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.12 Genetic Testing (e.g., BRCA1/2 for hereditary breast/ovarian cancer)

4.12.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.12.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.12.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.12.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.12.5 Approval Window: 10 business days (Complex Case, due to specialized review).

4.12.6 Clinical Documentation: Genetic counselor's consultation notes, detailed family pedigree demonstrating relevant cancer history (type, age of onset, specific relatives), previous genetic testing results (if any), and documentation of meeting established clinical criteria for testing (e.g., NCCN guidelines).

4.12.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Evelyn Reed, Oncology Lead. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.13 Outpatient Cardiac Catheterization (Diagnostic)

4.13.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required for diagnostic purposes.

4.13.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.13.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.13.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED.

4.13.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.13.6 Clinical Documentation: Cardiologist's consultation notes, symptoms of angina or other cardiac ischemia, results of non-invasive tests (e.g., stress test, echocardiogram) indicating high-risk findings or inconclusive results, and documentation of failed medical management.

4.13.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Marcus Thorne, Cardiology Lead. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

4.14 Interventional Pain Management Procedures (e.g., Epidural Steroid Injections, Facet Joint Injections)

4.14.1 MERIDIAN-GOLD: Pre-authorization NOT required for the first series of 3 injections within a 12-month period. Subsequent injections require pre-authorization.

4.14.2 MERIDIAN-SILVER: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all injections.

4.14.3 MERIDIAN-BRONZE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all injections.

4.14.4 CIVIC-BASE: Pre-authorization REQUIRED for all injections.

4.14.5 Approval Window: 5 business days (Standard).

4.14.6 Clinical Documentation: Pain management specialist or referring physician's notes, specific diagnosis (e.g., radiculopathy, degenerative disc disease), documentation of at least 6 weeks of failed conservative management (e.g., physical therapy, NSAIDs, oral corticosteroids), and relevant imaging (MRI/CT) demonstrating anatomical correlation to pain.

4.14.7 Appeal Route: Initial appeal to Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department, attention Dr. Amelia Khan, Medical Director. Subsequent appeal to Pacific Health Reviewers (Independent Review Organization).

5.0 CONTACT INFORMATION

5.1 For inquiries regarding specific pre-authorization requirements or status, please contact the Meridian Health Partners Utilization Review Department at (555) 876-5432 or via email at PA_Review@MeridianHP.org.

Document History:

- * V1.0 (2022-01-01): Initial release.
- * V2.0 (2023-01-15): Added CIVIC-BASE plan, updated appeal routes.
- * V3.0 (2024-01-01): Consolidated language, added specific procedure details.
- * V3.1 (2024-03-15): Clarified "Initial Course" for therapy, added Interventional Pain Management.